

knowing that their safety was guaranteed by oaths and permanent applications of Sovereign in the building. Though cordial at first, the session quickly escalated into a raging shouting match, threatening to escalate to a true war. Suddenly, the doors to the chamber flew open and a gateway from the Dreaming appeared, and Sir Seif's voice echoed in the Parliament, "Such as it was in our time of need, so it is again. Behold! Your true king returns!"

Escorted by the eshu knight, an older, still regal, David strode across the floor to the speaker's stand, but before he could reach it, Faerilyth cast herself into his arms. In a moving scene that silenced all present, the two declared their love for each other. Following his speech, in which he asked all Kithain to come together and fight the returning nightmares, the High King quickly left the chamber. Faced with questions about the quest and David's disappearance, Sir Seif declined, stating that that tale would remain secret until the Dreaming gave the sign to reveal it all. While the assembled delegates argued amongst themselves, Seif vanished, and has yet to be seen again.

Initially, the High King met with the public, but as time passed, he withdrew into the sanctuary at the heart of his stronghold. His strong and regal appearance upon his return proved a façade, and despite his wife's love and support, David was a broken man, plagued with chaotic dreams and imagery that made no sense to him. In his absence, the conservative Arcadian sidhe bribed and threatened their way to more influence, despite prevention attempts by both Princess Lenore and Regent Morwen. To avoid a possible conflict of the throne, Lenore remains heir to Concordia, until the day that David and Faerilyth have a sidhe child of their own.

Starvation of Dreams

Where the early 90s worked in favor of Glamour, the late part of the new millennium's first decade saw an increase in Banality. Not only did changelings find themselves at war with dark fae, but they also had to fend off increasing stagnation and disbelief. Even balefires that survived the Shattering slowly burned less brightly until only embers remained. Entire changeling communities fell asunder under bickering and physical conflicts over how to best handle what little Glamour an area produced.

Trusting their sovereigns to do the right thing by the Escheat and the Treaty of Concord, commoners turned to the Parliament of Dreams for help. In turn, the Parliament sent a request to the High King's court at Tara-Nar, but received a reply stating that the sidhe would investigate the matter further, while also suggesting austerity measures and the unification of local freeholds to better withstand Banality.

When massive numbers of changelings turned up at the seats of power in their kingdoms, the nobility felt compelled to act, and decreed that commoners were trespassing and that to ease their fears, they would contact Tara-Nar on their behalf. In response to this, David sent a proclamation throughout Concordia, stating that there was no need to worry since there was ample supply of Glamour to sustain them. The High King acknowledged that the times were difficult, but said that he would alleviate their worries by arranging mediators that would assist and make sure that all received their due. In despair, the commoners hoped

that the past they shared with many commoner nobles would make those members of the houses inclined to help others, but they were met with the same ignorant replies Tara-Nar provided.

Present Day

The dwindling balefires in Concordia have changed both the political and social landscapes more than any noble is willing to acknowledge. Changelings that returned during the decades following the Resurgence (and that have not succumbed to Bedlam or Undoing) are blessed by having built foundations to fall back on when Glamour supplies diminish. Meanwhile, others have to resort to extremes to survive Banality's growing influence on the world. Looking for change, but receiving no solution from their leadership, sinister organizations such as the Shadow Court continue to grow steadily by promising a new world in return for sacrifices and commitment in the name of their cause.

The massive rift between faerie nobility and commoners threatens more than the stability of changeling society by drawing attention from where it is needed. Increasing number of Thallain and Dark-Kin enter the Autumn world alongside monstrous chimera and nightmare monsters in order to prepare the world for the Elder Dark. At the same time, some find it easier to cast their lot with the Fomorians in order to avoid meeting their end, with "Better a nightmare than dreamless sleep" as their motto.

Nonetheless, the nobility is not immune to the changes in the world. Fear of losing standing and influence in the faerie community spreads throughout the houses. The practice of applying Sovereign in order to ensure loyalty to the court is increasing and has even spread to ennobled commoners. Conflict exists within houses on a larger scale than before, forcing the nobles to look for enemies where there were once brothers and sisters.

Insecurity and fear among nobles further escalates the tension with commoners, as freehold trods become focal points of increased military activity, and as refugees from fallen freeholds seek new sources of Glamour to sustain them. The Parliament of Dreams endlessly discusses possible solutions, but leaders of both courts delay, prevent, and sabotage agreements in order to maintain full control of their own power.

With another civil war threatening to break out, nobility looking for threats among their own, minions of the Elder Dark stalking the Kingdoms, and decreasing amounts of Glamour, the belief that these are the final days of Autumn and that the Long Winter is around the corner gains strength.

The Nature of the Fae

From one corner of the earth to another, one fact unites all fae that walk through the mortal world. All changelings have two halves, two natures that exist as a single whole. The true form of a changeling is called their *fae mien*, the fae form made of Glamour that can be seen by other fae and creatures of Glamour. That half of themselves is hidden away, protected from the harsh Banality of the Autumn world by their *mortal seeming*. Which one is viewed entirely depends on the person